Grit + Grace Doula

FREE FAMILY EDUCATION · GUIDE 01

Your Birth, Your Voice

A Personal Birth Preferences Workbook

A practical workbook for naming birth priorities, preparing questions, and sharing preferences with a birth team.

Printable workbook · US Letter

01 · BEGIN WITH WHAT MATTERS

Your priorities belong in the conversation

Birth preferences are personal. There is no single right list or ideal way to give birth.

Start by naming what helps you feel informed, respected, and supported. You may have clear preferences, open questions, or both. A preference is a starting point for discussion, not a contract or a prediction.

Consider what matters to you about being included in decisions, having a support person nearby, privacy, movement, quiet, touch, or updates. Your priorities may change as you learn more or as circumstances change.

Top five birth priorities

1. What matters most to me	Why this matters
2. What matters most to me	Why this matters
3. What matters most to me	4. What matters most to me
5. What matters most to me	

Keep room for change

A useful plan can include both preferences and questions. You can revisit it with your care team at any time.

02 · YOUR PEOPLE

Build a support team that fits

List the people you want involved and what you would like them to know.

Your team may include a midwife or physician, nurses, a doula, a partner, family, friends, or an interpreter. Ask your birth setting about visitor limits, who can stay during procedures, and how support people can participate.

Share only the information you want each person to have. Decide who can receive updates, who can speak with the care team if you ask, and who should be contacted if plans change.

Support-team directory

Person / role	How to reach them	How I'd like them to help

Worksheet

Who should receive updates?

Who may speak for me if I ask?

People I do not want contacted or present

03 · COMMUNICATION & SETTING

Make the room feel more like yours

Small details can help the team understand what respectful communication looks like to you.

Communication preferences

- ☐ Please explain options and allow time for questions when possible.
- ☐ Please speak directly to me and check that I understand.
- ☐ Please ask before touching or starting a nonurgent procedure.
- ☐ Please include my chosen support person when I invite them.
- ☐ An interpreter or communication aid would help me: _____
- ☐ Names, pronouns, or language preferences I want the team to know: _____

Labor environment preferences

- ☐ Lighting, sound, temperature, or privacy that helps me
- ☐ Music, quiet, or other items I may want to bring
- ☐ Movement, positions, or access needs I want to ask about
- ☐ Cultural, spiritual, or family practices I want to discuss
- ☐ Facility policies or restrictions I need to understand

Worksheet

What helps me feel grounded?

How should people check in with me?

04 · COMFORT & PAIN RELIEF

Learn your options without pressure

Comfort measures and medication choices are individual. You do not need to commit to one approach in advance.

People may consider breathing, position changes, movement, water, touch, warmth or coolness, focused relaxation, medication, or a combination. What is available and appropriate depends on the person, the moment, and the birth setting.

Ask your obstetric clinician or midwife to explain the options available where you plan to give birth, including benefits, risks, timing, and any individual factors that may matter. ACOG notes that people may change their minds about pain relief; asking for it does not make a birth less valid.

Comfort preferences to discuss

- ☐ Ways I would like support people to offer comfort
- ☐ Touch I welcome, touch I do not want, and how to ask
- ☐ Movement or positions I want to learn about
- ☐ Medication or anesthesia questions for my clinician
- ☐ How I would like choices presented if I am focused or tired

> **Doula role**
>
> A doula can offer nonclinical comfort and help you ask questions. A doula does not recommend, administer, or provide medical pain treatment.

05 · QUESTIONS FOR YOUR CARE TEAM

Ask what is specific to you

Use these prompts to prepare for prenatal appointments or a conversation with your birth setting.

Possible questions

- ☐ Which comfort and pain-relief options are available here?
- ☐ What would make an option unavailable or need to change for me?
- ☐ How are urgent decisions explained and consent discussed?
- ☐ Can I move, eat, drink, use water, or change position here? What policies apply?
- ☐ Who can be with me during labor, a procedure, or a transfer?
- ☐ How are language access and communication needs arranged?
- ☐ What newborn procedures or routine care should I learn about before birth?

My provider questions

Question	What I learned / next step
Question	What I learned / next step
Question	What I learned / next step

06 · IF PLANS CHANGE

Make a flexible contingency plan

Unexpected events can change timing, location, or available choices. Planning questions can make the next conversation easier.

A contingency plan is not a forecast. Ask your care team which situations could change your preferences and how they will explain time-sensitive choices. You can also decide who should stay with you, who can update family, and what helps you feel heard.

Contingency planning

If we need to change location or plan, I would like to know...

Questions I want answered when time allows

Support person who can stay / help communicate

Person who can update others

What may help me feel supported if I feel overwhelmed

In an urgent situation

Follow your clinical team's instructions. Ask them to explain the situation and options when the circumstances allow.

07 · FIRST MOMENTS WITH BABY

Share initial newborn preferences

Your baby's clinician can explain recommended care and any time-sensitive needs. These prompts help you start that conversation.

Topics to discuss with the newborn care team

- ☐ How the team will explain routine newborn assessments and procedures
- ☐ Whether skin-to-skin contact is available and what could affect it
- ☐ How feeding preferences and support will be discussed
- ☐ Who may be present for newborn care and updates
- ☐ How urgent concerns will be communicated
- ☐ What follow-up and contact instructions we should receive before leaving

Worksheet

Initial preferences or questions	Newborn clinician / clinic and contact

Individual guidance matters

This workbook does not recommend or decline newborn procedures. Discuss the care appropriate for your baby with the pediatric or newborn clinician.

08 · ONE PAGE TO SHARE

Birth preferences summary

Copy the details you want your team to see. Keep this brief, flexible, and easy to update.

My birth preferences at a glance

Name / how I want to be addressed	Support people and roles
My top priorities	Communication preferences / access needs
Comfort preferences and questions	Newborn care questions / initial preferences
If plans change, please...	Important contacts or details to confirm

For the team

These are preferences for discussion. Please explain options, urgent needs, and changes as the situation allows.

09 · BEFORE THE NEXT APPOINTMENT

Preparation checklist

Choose what is useful now and return to the rest later.

My next steps

- [ ] Share my questions with my obstetric clinician or midwife.
- [ ] Ask my hospital or birth center about its policies and available options.
- [ ] Confirm who I want in my support team and share relevant preferences.
- [ ] Add important care-team and support-person contacts to my phone and this workbook.
- [ ] Review my summary if circumstances or preferences change.
- [ ] Keep a copy where my chosen support person can find it.

A NOTE FROM TEESEE

Teesee's care centers the family's choices. This workbook is a place to gather questions and name what support can look like; the care team can explain medical options for your circumstances.

Optional reflection · Isaiah 41:10

Optional Christian reflection on courage and comfort; no verse text is quoted.

Sources and further reading

Medications for Pain Relief During Labor and Delivery
American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists

Prenatal Care
American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists

Educational information reviewed against these sources on October 14, 2026. Confirm current guidance with your qualified care team.

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